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The Maasai of Matapato

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PHASE II. THE CONVERGENCE OF THE MANYAT FOR EUNOTO

Two dances recur in *eunoto* and express complementary aspects of moranhood. In the 'lion dance', the lion-skin trophy headdresses are worn by their owners or on less formal occasions by some other moran. This dance is a motif that encapsulates the exuberant spirit of moranhood. The other dance, *emosiroi*, is the exact converse: subdued and lacking the element of exuberant spontaneity. It is performed by visiting delegations [148](#) and by moran when their patrons wish to impose their authority. The elders themselves may join in and married women may faintly follow it as onlookers. This dance seems to express unity and submissiveness to ritual obligations. It bears the imprint of peace and conformity as opposed to the competitive associations of the lion dance: the 4th quadrant of Figure 8b as opposed to the 2nd. In Maasai idiom, dancing tends to be synonymous with 'play', but *emosiroi* is a dance when this would be an inappropriate term.

Episode 2. Ruffling the firestick patrons and the ritual of counter-rebellion. The Meto manyata arrived too late to allow the first stage of the *eunoto* proper to be performed at the new moon towards the end of March. It was therefore necessary to delay this stage a further month. During this period, an incident in the Meto village provoked the firestick patrons and dealt a further blow to the prestige of the Meto moran. One of the firestick patrons at the festival was Mebugu, the ritual leader of Nyankusi ^L. His wife was a manyata-mother at Meto and it was highly appropriate that he should attend the festival. However, it was important that he above all other firestick patrons should be respected and maintain his dignity, and also his wife, who by custom had been chosen for him by his age-group. One evening, a Meto moran entered her hut and started to make love with her daughter, ignoring the mother's presence and protests. She was furious and complained to the patrons. They regarded the incident as an outrage against Mebugu himself, and a

[535
Dance](#)[554
Status, Role, And
Prestige](#)[561
Age Stratification](#)[576
Etiquette](#)[578
Ingroup Antagonisms](#)[681
Sanctions](#)[754
Sorcery](#)[796
Organized Ceremonial](#)[824
Ethnobotany](#)

symptom of the prevailing disrespect among all moran. When Mebugu heard next morning, he could not conceal his anger. As ritual leader, he had a powerful curse, but he was also obliged to respect the collective will of his age mates. Their first task was to coerce him to restrain himself while they took on themselves the responsibility for castigating the moran.

The Meto moran were assembled to the west of their village and moran from the larger village were called over to join them. The response of the patrons throughout the morning was similar to that described for all such occasions when they assemble to harangue the moran. They emphasised their power to curse and simply abandon the festival, while signalling at the same time that the harangue was an end in itself that stopped short of fulfilling these threats. This is, in other words, an established procedure when elders seek to establish their authority over the moran: an authoritarian ritual of counter-rebellion. About 40 elders ordered about 100 moran, 30 wives and 10 girls to sit in separate groups. The three moran spokesmen sat with their spears among the patrons. The general description by elders of such occasions emphasises the fear it generates among the moran and their mothers. Certainly everyone seemed to take the harangue itself seriously enough. Three times in the course of the morning, firestick patrons worked up a display of exasperation, ordering the moran to leave the meeting. This then prompted a number of elders looking seriously shaken to leave the meeting and by implication abandon the festival also. A cry would then be raised and moran and wives rushed to them clutching fistfuls of grass in both hands, invoking its life-giving powers and in effect appealing to a higher authority. The elders could not ignore this, and were forced to turn back. In some instances, this was more than just moral coercion that would in any case have obliged the elders to return to their places. There was even a hint of physical coercion. One slight elder who neatly dodged fistfuls of grass waved at him found his way barred by two ■ 149 strapping moran thrusting grass within inches of his face until he turned back, their broad grins contrasting with his trembling anger. This note of hilarity among the younger people at the more histrionic moments, countered the counter-rebellion. It set a limit to the freedom of the elders to abandon the moran to their fate. Following the third outburst of anger, the harangue was adjourned until the afternoon. Meanwhile, the moran were told to brew tea for all the elders and to perform the subdued *emosiroi* dance in each of the villages.

When they met for the second session, some of the patrons had cut fresh whips up to ten feet in length. This was to become a feature at certain points throughout the festival. The patrons agreed not to threaten to abandon the festival. At the same time, they warned the moran not to attempt again to coerce them with grass that God had placed on the ground. The moran were again ordered to leave the meeting several times when the elders' anger mounted, as if to exercise their right to obedience, but no elders stomped from the meeting. During the breaks in moments of pique, certain patrons occasionally cracked their long whips at unsubdued groups of moran as though they were frisky cattle. The moran would dutifully retire to a safer distance, 'running away' from the elders' anger, although still sometimes giggling. In the course of the afternoon, the elders appeared to have established control over the moran and over their own anger. The offending moran was ordered to pay Mebugu a heavier fine than he could readily afford. Mebugu by now was quite mollified, and led the blessing of all the moran. As the elders dispersed, he remained with a small group of age mates, entertaining them with a display of joking and good humour. They encouraged him, rather as moran closely support an age mate after a bout of shaking.

That evening, the Meto moran and six elders processed dancing *emosiroi* to the larger village. They were received by a line of moran, wives and girls, greeting one another in turn with touching palms. Later that night, the largest dance I had seen up to that point built up in the Meto village with many visitors from the larger village. Prominent in the dancing was the exuberant 'lion' dance, displaying the less submissive aspect of moranhood. It also suggested a new spirit of solidarity between the two villages that had been absent earlier, when the larger village was the focus of all dance and play, and the smaller, newer, gaucher Meto village had a deserted air.

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